the UN and special envoy to the Middle East, found this decision wise.[122] However, he suspected that it was taken primarily to assuage Pakistan's concerns vis-à-vis India. Only India, he argued (somewhat spuriously) had the capacity to play a decisive role in Afghanistan's defence sector. Iran's troubled ties with the US, the CAR's limited capacity, and Chinese and Russian reluctance, convinced Indian officials that the West aimed this decision solely at India. It fed into India's apprehensions towards Washington's tilt towards Pakistan, that only increased when the US refused to entertain Indian military involvement despite Afghan requests (despite the fact that levels of violence in Kashmir went down after 9/11, mostly due to US pressure on Musharraf).

Vikram Sood, then chief of R&AW, clarified to the political leadership that US was not going to touch India-specific militant groups, and would only target Al Qaeda and the Taliban.[123] 'So if you [political leadership] think that they will help you sort your problem, forget it. That's not going to happen', he counseled. But the partisans were euphoric about the whole affair and wanted to be friendly with the US in the hope of a high strategic yield on the security front. As Sood put it, the BJP wanted to get out of a failed marriage by building strategic links with the US, but this was not how it worked, as such collaboration on Afghanistan was not in US interests. Shyam Saran concurs that given India's policy of containing Pakistan, the idea of militarily aligning with the US in the wake of 9/11 was a potent one, but it did not happen.[124] For Arun Sahgal, who was then the Director of Net Assessment at the Integrated Defence Staff, says that India's approach began with euphoria, but 'then the opportunities started to cease ... and the realisation came that the Americans are not in it for us, they are in it for themselves'.[125] Other senior diplomats such as Rajiv Sikri, term the political leadership's enthusiasm for aligning with the US as unwarranted.[126] India's initial enthusiasm to offer naval and air bases was rooted in its rationale of showing loyalty to an outraged US. Indian bases, however, could not have helped the US pursue its war in Afghanistan. All India could do was help with air and naval supplies, but the US would still need to cross Pakistan's airspace. 'So what good were our bases in India? The bases that were more important for them were in Central Asia, and they [US] got a few,' Sikri argues.[127] Another source of the Indian bureaucracy's caution against the US was rooted in differences over US